

THE CHOICE OVERLOAD

WHY YOU SHOULD LIMIT YOUR OPTIONS

Intuitively you might think that more means more. The more options we take into consideration, the better our final decision. The more choices we have, the happier we are. But sometimes the opposite is true: the greater the choice, the higher our expectations – and the more we worry that we will make the wrong decision. It is the so-called paradox of choice that the American business professor Sheena Iyengar demonstrated in a legendary experiment.

In a supermarket she offered a variety of jams for shoppers to try: six different varieties on one day, twenty-four varieties on another. With the smaller selection, 40 per cent tried the jams and 30 per cent bought a jar. The bigger selection attracted 60 per cent of the shoppers, but only 2 per cent bought a jar of jam. The conclusion: choice is alluring but confusing.

How do we solve this paradox of choice in our day-to-day lives? The psychology professor Barry Schwarz has a simple recommendation: reduce your choice. For example, in a restaurant, pick the first dish on the menu that you like the look of, and then immediately close the menu. Because the more options you juggle in your mind, the more dissatisfied you will be.

More is difficult.

